

Chapter 42

Russian “narrative” imperatives and adjacent phenomena

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A “narrative imperative” is a verbal form that bears the morphology of a conventional directive imperative but lacks its semantics. Rather than imparting a command (order, wish or any other imperative meaning), it serves as a vehicle for conveying a story. My central claim is that narrative imperatives share the (functionally deficient) structural template with the conventional ones. The difference between them boils down to the specifications in the pragmatic domain, accomplished via a particular diachronic route. It is also the case that narrative imperatives are most frequently encountered as constituents in pseudo-coordinated structures (equivalent crudely to *He went and died on me*, where *went* is a bleached element). Despite this consistent overlap, I treat pseudo-coordination as a separate (albeit related) phenomenon.

Keywords: imperatives, narrative, narrative imperatives, pseudo-coordination, Russian

1 Introduction: background and previous analyses

The two underlined verb forms in (1) illustrate the phenomenon targeted in this paper. Both *podvernīs* ‘turn up’ and *načni* ‘begin’ are morphological imperatives that fail to convey any of the usual meanings associated with this form. Dubbed “dramatic” or “narrative” imperatives (NIs henceforth), they have enjoyed quite a bit of attention in the (descriptive and cognitive linguistics) literature.¹

¹In the interest of space preservation, I provide the most bare-bones sourcing information for my examples, as details are easy to obtain via a reverse search. Constructed examples – those

- (1) A tut ešte podvernīs drugoi gimnazist – i
 and here also turn.up.PFV.IMP.SG other pupil and
načni xvastat'sja novymi časami.
 begin.PFV.IMP.SG to.boast new watch
 'A different pupil showed up here and began to show off his new watch.'
 (I. Turgenev. *Časy*. via [Kniazev 2007](#), shortened)

Table 1 supplies a snippet of the inflectional pattern for *načat* 'to begin'. Particularly instructive here is the comparison between the narrative imperative and the ordinary one: the former, while bereft of any agreement markers, can be used in any person; the latter is person-restricted and more endowed morphologically. NIs can only be formed with perfective verbs ([Fortuin 2001](#): 138).²

Table 1: Conjugation of *načat* 'to begin.PFV'

	‘NARRATIVE’ IMPERATIVE	IMPERATIVE	FUTURE
I	načni	–	načnu
you.SG	načni	načni	načneš
(s)he	načni	–	načnet
we	načni	(načnemte)	načnem
you.PL	načni	načnite	načnete
they	načni	–	načnut

The NI's origin and its very nature are controversial. NIs are claimed to encode past sudden, “out of the blue”, events ([Vinogradov 1947](#): 449-452, [Khrakovskii & Volodin 2001](#): 245-246, a.o.) – the actions that are unexpected or inappropriate ([Isachenko 1960](#), [Fortuin 2001, 2008](#), [Kor Chahine 2007](#)). They carry an “expressive component”, which renders them especially fitting for the colloquial register ([Isachenko 1960](#): 502, [Kor Chahine 2007](#)) and dovetails with their function as a device for story-telling.

This picture requires some refinements, however. First, NIs are overwhelmingly attested in constructions like (2), which fall within the purview of “pseudo-coordination” (PC). In PC contexts, the first element (typically, a verb of move-

not accompanied by any metadata – were assessed by five informants on the scale of 1-5. In situations where the reported glosses were modified, the resulting sentences were checked by the same set of informants. Judgments are presented in the following format: ‘*’ = 1, ‘?’ = 2, ‘??’ = 3, ‘?’ = 4.

²To render the examples more reader-friendly, I will henceforth use the abbreviation NI for “narrative imperative” and IMP for “canonical imperative”.

ment or position) is semantically bleached or grammaticalized (Carden & Pesetsky 1977, Cardinaletti & Giusti 2001, Kjeldahl 2010, Biberauer & Vikner 2017, Ross 2021, a.o.). Just like English *went* in “*He went and died on me*” does not supply any motion component and hence does not entail a transition to a new physical location, so too, Russian *voz’mi* ‘take’ has nothing to do with the baseline dictionary definition of ‘take’, “getting something into one’s hands or one’s possession”. Instead, at its core, *voz’mi* conveys roughly that the event denoted by the lexical verb is unexpected (Fortuin 2001, Kor Chahine 2007, Nau et al. 2019, Bonnot & Vassilaki 2021, Weiss 2022a,b, 2023, etc.).

- (2) A Pozner *voz’mi* **i** brjakni v svoem šou, čto ...
 and Pozner take.NI and blab.NI in self’s show that ...
 ‘And Pozner (unexpectedly) blabbed in his show that...’ (web)

Most researchers treat instances like (1) and (2) as part and parcel of the same phenomenon, so that most of the descriptive generalizations above apply to both – solitary, i.e. free-standing, NIs and those that are pseudo-conjoined with *voz’mi*. For some, the link between V.NI and TAKE.NI + V.NI is explicit (e.g., Isachenko 1960: 502, Kor Chahine 2007); others do not necessarily attempt to divorce the two formally, though often concede that TAKE attenuates the meaning in some way (e.g., Vinogradov 1947, Prokopovich 1969, Israeli 2001, Jakab 2005, Daiber 2009, Moloshnaia 2009, etc.). As Fortuin (2001): 149, I believe that V.NI is not isomorphic with TAKE.NI + V.NI: the latter is the result of a compositional procedure that combines TAKE with the lexical verb in the narrative imperative form. Though my primary preoccupation in this paper is the account of the solitary (non-coordinated) NIs, I do offer some reflections on the matter of PC and the contribution of the bleached verb (§3).³

So, what precisely is an narrative imperative? One popular strand of analysis situates NIs in the inventory of past tense forms. Some view the form as a “relic” of aorist (e.g., Vinogradov 1947, Shakhmatov 1925/2001, Stender-Peterson 1930). A version of this idea is pursued in Daiber (2009). In Gronas (2006), we find

³In response to Anonymous Reviewer’s request for clarification, I hasten to reiterate that the preliminary generalizations on the meaning of NIs outlined earlier as well as the ensuing literature overview in this section encompass both – uncoordinated NIs and those in PC configurations, precisely because most investigators of the narrative imperative do not ascribe the degree of autonomy to the TAKE-component that I believe it deserves. With this caveat aside, I actually cannot conceive of any particular problem if we disregard the TAKE-component. Crucial for the following exposition are the properties of the lexical verb. To make this more transparent, I modified the glosses accordingly.

a contention that NIs arose as a consequence of a dual potential for the development of Proto-Indo-European *oi-optative, which, according to this analysis, could resolve either in modal semantics (leading to the canonical imperative) or the preterial semantics (with Russian NIs being the result of this route).

One immediate problem for appraising NI as an instance of (a special) past tense, raised in *Isachenko (1960)*, is that, contrary to the established wisdom, the NI does not necessarily encode preterit – it is akin to the “historical present”, which conveys the events of the “actual past” with the morphology of the *presens*, rendering the narrative “livelier”, more “dynamic and dramatic” (*ibid.*, p. 500). The upshot is that in *Isachenko*’s assessment, (3a) is synonymous with (3b). In §2.3, I add an additional empirical bit that militates against the view that NIs serve strictly to convey past tense. As it turns out, they are also compatible with future-oriented contexts.

- (3) a. Ja k nemu po-xorošemu, a on nakriči na menja.
I to him well but he scream.NI on me
‘I’m being nice to him – and suddenly he yells at me.’
(slightly modified)
- b. ... a on kak nakričit na menja.
but he how screams.3SG on me
‘I’m being nice to him – and suddenly he yells at me.’
(*Isachenko 1960*: 500-501)

Under the second analytical approach, NIs are reckoned to instantiate a special imperative form (various implementations in *Ebeling 1956*, *Isachenko 1960*, *Jakab 2005*, *Fortuin 2001, 2008*, *Holvoet 2018*). One generative proposal (found in *Jakab 2005*) relates NIs in (4) to other non-canonical uses of morphological imperative in Russian.⁴ She argues that in (4), V moves to C, driven by an IMP-feature (with the subject sitting in the topicalized position in the CP).⁵

- (4) My idem spokojno, a on upadi.
we are.walking calmly but he fall.NI
‘We’re walking calmly, and he all of a sudden falls.’

⁴A brief aside: Russian morphological imperatives appear in a variety of robustly non-imperative contexts – in addition to the NIs considered here, imperative forms are used in, e.g., conditionals and necessitives. Conversely, certain non-imperative morphology – e.g., past tense and infinitives – may serve to convey the standard range of imperative meanings. For descriptive work see, e.g., *Biriulin & Khrakovskii (1992)*, *Dobrushina (2008, 2016b)*, *Khrakovskii & Volodin (2001)*

⁵This IMP is understood as a semantic feature associated with the illocutionary force. Its specific contribution in NI contexts is left unexplained.

(modified from Jakab 2005: 339)

While there is merit to the idea that NIs are a special form of the imperative, it is hard to accept that the IMP-feature is somehow involved in the NI configurations for a transparent reason. These constructions are devoid of the meanings that typically accompany canonical imperatives: there is no command, prescription, advice, permission, wish, etc. A sentence like (4), most naturally uttered in the context of a story-telling exercise, simply relays the event. It is true that it carries a tinge of unexpectedness. I suggest, however, that this mirative property arises naturally as a consequence of the pragmatic demands: after all, if this is a highly specialized form used for constructing a story, it is expected to embed content that transcends the quotidian. In other words, while the indicative morphology is “neutral” and hence appropriate for conveying ordinary and unusual events alike, the *narrative* morphology is reserved for extraordinary events. More importantly though, the sense of unexpectedness is channeled via syntactic means, as clauses featuring NIs are liable to be introduced by a contrastive coordinator *a* ‘and, but’ (on the properties of this element see, e.g., Malchukov 2004, Mikaelian & Zalizniak 2005, Jasinskaja & Zeevat 2008, Jasinskaja 2010 and references therein).

To recap thus far: there are two analytic perspectives on the nature of NIs. Some consider NIs a special past tense form that owes its provenance to the aorist, a now extinct form that, in the earliest East Slavic writing, “served as the most common means for conveying events that took place in the past” (Borkovskii & Kuznetsov 2006: 257). Ascribing to the NI the status “relic of aorist” is predicated not strictly on the meaning but also on the partial morphological overlap illustrated in Table 2. For a subset of verbs (those ending in *-iti*, e.g. *xval-iti* ‘to praise’), the second / third person singular aorist and the second person (canonical) imperative are identical. It is worth emphasizing that the convergence of forms is not absolute: all the non-*iti* verbs (like the sample *zn-ati* ‘to know’) distinguish 2/3.SG.AOR from 2/3.SG.IMP.

On the other side of the ideological fence are those who deem NIs to be an instance of the imperative. Their rationale is likewise grounded in morphology: independent of the verb type, a narrative imperative is formed in exactly the same way as its canonical counterpart. For all intents and purposes, an NI is a morphological imperative in second singular, as shown in Table 3.

We are now facing a curious contradiction: on the one hand, there is a widely shared intuition that the NI’s meaning is closer to the one conveyed by the old

⁶The third person imperative form is presumed to be identical to the second person form. It is attested only when “the incitement for action is directed towards the divine force” (Gorshkova & Khaburgaev 1981: 313). The Table is partially replicated from Nesset (2015), pp. 141 and 155.

Table 2: Aorist and imperative in Old East Slavic⁶

	xval-iti ‘to praise’		zn-ati ‘to know’	
	AORIST	IMPERATIVE	AORIST	IMPERATIVE
I	xvalixŭ	–	znaxŭ	–
you.SG	xvali	= xvali	zna	≠ znai
s/he	xvali	= (xvali)	zna	≠ (znai)
we	xvalixomŭ	–	znaxomŭ	–
you.PL	xvaliste	xvalite	znaste	znajte
they	xvališa	–	znaša	–

Table 3: The two imperatives in Russian

	poxval-it’ ‘to praise’		uzn-at’ ‘to find out’	
	NARRATIVE	CANONICAL	NARRATIVE	CANONICAL
I	poxvali	–	uznaj	–
you.SG	poxvali	= poxvali	uznaj	= uznaj
s/he	poxvali	–	uznaj	–
we	poxvali	–	uznaj	–
you.PL	poxvali	≠ poxvalite	uznaj	≠ uznajte
they	poxvali	–	uznaj	–

aorist and “has nothing to do with the imperative mood” (Borkovskii & Kuznetsov 2006: 280). For Daiber (2009), the point of semantic convergence is “simultaneity”, whereby the NI “shares the tense of the general situation it is embedded in” (p. 23) (see also Fortuin 2001: 138). He ascribes the same simultaneity to the aorist which, for him, is its “prototypical meaning”, since this verbal form itself is “defined as ‘present of the past’.” (ibid, p. 11). On the other hand, it is very hard to overlook the fact that the narrative imperative’s morphological exterior is indistinguishable from its canonical counterpart. Why should a construction that has “nothing to do with the imperative mood” borrow its shape?

Mine is an attempt to reconcile these two observations – and respond to both sets of insights. The core point I defend here is that the narrative imperative is an imperative specimen that owes its existence to the obsolescence of the aorist. In syntax, it shares certain structural idiosyncrasies with the ordinary imperative – what it lacks is the directive force (*pace* Jakab 2005) and subject restrictions. Integral to my analysis is the partial morphological overlap between the aorist and the imperative (in Table 2), which paved the way for the imperative to “sneak

into” the indicative realm. The upshot is that the imperative structural template is retrofitted with a new function, consistent with the input “morphological imperative but with no imperative component”.

2 Proposal: overview

My key claim is that from the standpoint of syntax, NIs are genuine imperatives. Both types rely on a (reduced) structural template. What distinguishes them is the feature specifications: NIs lose the illocutionary force of the canonical imperatives and, along with it, the restriction ensuring that the subjects are addressee-oriented.

Hence, our starting point is the structural homogeneity of the two imperative types. §2.1 sets the stage by outlining some authoritative theoretical proposals made for the canonical imperatives. I adopt the view that (canonical) imperatives distinguish themselves from other clause types and outline the framework for dealing with subjects and the featural makeup involved in the imperatives. In §2.2–2.4, I explicate how the analysis adopted for the conventional imperatives carries over to the NIs. §2.5 is dedicated to diachrony. I close with some reflections on the nature of pseudo-coordination in §3.

2.1 Canonical imperatives

We distinguish two syntactic approaches to the architecture of the canonical imperative clause (the “Eat your vegetables!”-type). On one side are those who believe that imperatives feature the same basic sentential template as other clause types (Potsdam 2007, 2019), perhaps with certain featural idiosyncrasies (e.g., Jensen 2003 posits a special T_{IMP} , Isac 2015 endorses a non-finite T).

Their opponents argue that the imperative clause is structurally unique in some sense. To begin with, there is something special about its tense – person specification aside, imperatives tend to have only one form and embed reference to the future time. To capture this property, many proposed that imperatives lack (at least) TP (Zanuttini 1991, Platzack & Rosengren 1997, Rupp 1999, Han 2000, Zeijlstra 2004, Den Dikken & Blasco 2007, Alcázar & Saltarelli 2014, etc.). For Alcázar & Saltarelli (2014), e.g., the imperative clause takes on the shape in (5), where a special directive v^* is licensed by illocutionary/imperative force in C. With the theta roles of the speaker and the addressee assigned in the Specs of v^* and v , respectively, the future orientation of the imperatives is a “corollary of the performative nature of the expression: [Speaker_i “prescribes” at time $t...$]” (p. 106).

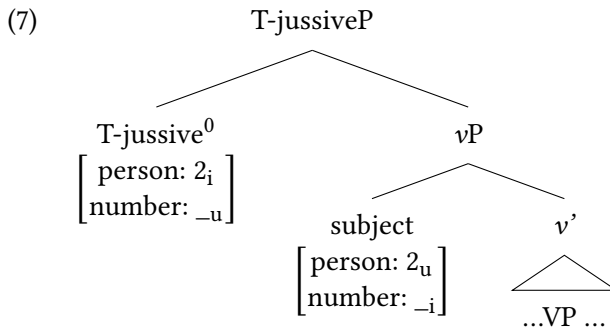
- (5) [_{CP} [_C IF [_{vP} I_(speaker at time t) [_{v*} prescribes [_{vP} you_(addressee) to V]]]]]

The imperative clause in Platzack & Rosengren (1997) is even more radical. It is stripped of the functional projections that carry the finiteness feature – so that along with FinP, MoodP and TP are also absent.

The second idiosyncrasy of the imperative is its subject. Its obvious quirks – such as its preference for being non-overt aside, the property relevant for my present purposes is its addressee-orientation. It is demonstrated by (6), whose subject must carry the second person feature in order to co-occur with *yourself*. For Zanuttini et al. (2012), these data indicate that the restriction holds only of imperative contexts (6a). It must be so in view of (6b): evidently, quantificational subjects (as well as proper names) resist binding the second person anaphor in declarative (and more generally, non-imperative) clauses.

- (6) a. Everyone wash yourself!
 b. *Everyone washed yourself. (Zanuttini et al. 2012: 1238-1239)

To account for this property, Zanuttini (2008) and Zanuttini et al. (2012) propose a special Jussive Phrase, which is only compatible with certain clause-types (imperatives, promissives, and exhortatives). Its head bears the interpretable second person ϕ -feature. When sufficiently local, it agrees with and binds the imperative subject. The mechanism is demonstrated in (7) (simplified from Zanuttini et al. 2012).⁷ The Agree operation between T-jussive⁰ and the subject enables them to share the number feature. Being a lambda operator, jussive⁰ binds the subject, passing on its second person specification – this, in turn, derives the addressee restriction.



⁷Per Zanuttini et al. (2012), T enters the structure with a case and a number feature but not a person feature. T+jussiveP is a graphic shorthand representing the structure resulting from T to jussive⁰ movement. I put aside the issue of case.

Performativity is another famous trait of the imperative (Sadock & Zwicky 1985, Ninan 2005, Portner 2007, Kaufmann 2012, a.o.). As observed in Portner (2007), imperatives, like (8), are distinct from their modal synonyms (i.e., *you must eat your vegetables*, *you must have a glass of wine*): “modal sentences [...] can be called ‘true’ or ‘false’, while imperatives intuitively cannot” (ibid, p. 363). This is why (9) is incoherent as a response to either utterance in (8). It is worth pointing out as well that the range of speech acts encoded by the imperatives is not limited to commands. In addition to this “prototypical” illocutionary force, imperatives may channel requests, suggestions, advice, warnings, instructions, etc. (see, e.g., Condoravdi & Lauer 2012).

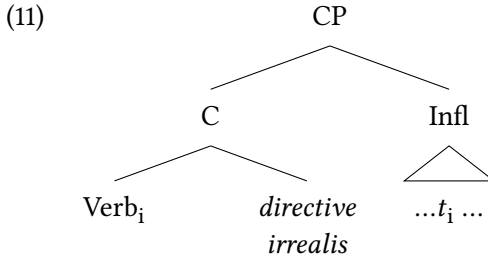
- (8) a. Eat your vegetables! (order)
 b. Have a glass of wine! (invitation)
- (9) #That’s false.

The final (and rather contentious) issue concerns the division of labor between pragmatics and semantics in deriving the imperative meanings (for a brief survey see Charlow 2014). I will rely on a well-established analysis developed in Han (2000, 2001, 2019) (although with a handful of modifications). Han suggests that force and modality are both involved in the LF-makeup of the imperative. She posits an IMP-feature in C, which maps onto the force operator, dubbed *directive*. This operator takes the proposition that has the modality of unrealized interpretation represented as *irrealis(p)*, where *p* denotes core propositional content. “Importantly, [...] the traditional truth-conditional semantics interprets up to *irrealis(p)* and *directive* is interpreted by pragmatics” (Han 2019: 227), as represented schematically in (10).

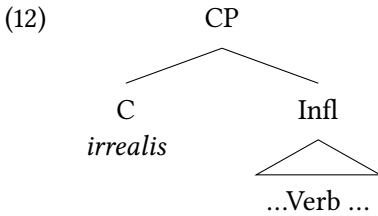
- (10) *directive* (*irrealis(p)*)
 pragmatics ↑truth-conditional content

The *directive* operator is responsible for producing the range of illocutionary forces alluded to earlier. To accomplish this, Han makes use of a discourse module called Plan Set, defined as a set of propositions that itemizes the addressee’s intentions. In a canonical imperative context (i.e., when a command is issued), the speaker instructs the addressee to add a proposition to their Plan Set. In non-canonical situations, the *directive* operator acts in accordance with the exigencies of the context. For instance, by uttering *Come in!* (permission) to a person who knocks, the speaker simply acknowledges the visitor’s design to enter. So, instead of instructing the guest to update their Plan Set, the host accepts the one that already exists.

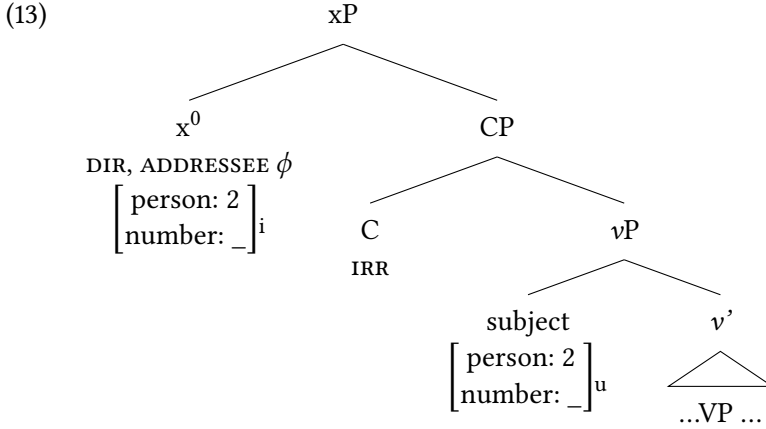
For imperatives proper, Han (2000) proposes the structure in (11). C^0 hosts the full IMP-complex (specified for both, *directive* and *irrealis*) – with *directive* driving the verb movement, as indicated.



In the absence of the *directive* feature, C^0 , carrying *irrealis*, selects an infinitive or a subjunctive Infl. Hence, subjunctives and infinitivals require an operator whose feature composition represents a proper subset of IMP. The verb stays immobile in these circumstances, as in (12).



In short, among the clause types, the imperative evinces a handful of eccentricities. Most notably, it imposes the person limitations on its subject and restricts its tense to future orientation. Additionally, it runs the gamut of illocutionary forces – from prototypical commands to invitations to prescriptions. I capitalize on all these insights and borrow some of the theoretical apparatus (albeit with modifications) outlined above. Ultimately, I arrive at (13).



The sections following contain the specifics: §2.1.1 deals with (the lack of) tense and its intersection with irrealis in canonical imperatives; §2.1.2 outlines the properties of the newly introduced x^0 ; §2.1.3 discusses a possible morphological range of C's complements; §2.1.4 summarizes the discussion.

2.1.1 Tense and irrealis

Beginning with the temporal value, I assume a “defective” structure for the canonical imperative in Russian: I join the popular camp and accept that imperative clauses are TP-less. Under the treatment entertained here, it is the feature IRR (akin to Han’s *irrealis*) that serves as a surrogate for tense. With Han, I place IRR in C^0 – and assume that it contributes to the truth-conditional content of the clause. My suggestion is that IRR latches onto the syntactic configuration. In cases of unrealized T, the temporal-modal value is fixed relative to some illocutionary properties of the clause – IRR relativizes events to the components of the speech act. A helpful way of thinking about this is found Jensen (2004) who points out that there are two events embedded in the imperative: a speech act event (ordering, prescribing, warning etc.), anchored in the utterance time (T_U), and an event posterior to T_U , encoded by the proposition itself (i.e., the action that the speaker wants the addressee to carry out – the “unrealized interpretation” in Han’s terms). I take the former to be associated with the performative layer, and the latter to be within the remit of my $C[IRR]$.

2.1.2 Speech Act domain: the features of x^0

One of the innovative aspects pursued here implicates the performative layer just mentioned. An intuitively compelling idea is to reflect the representation

implied by (10) in syntax. I do this by de-coupling IRR and DIR (Han's *directive*). Because DIR is a pragmatic mediator, I put it outside of the proposition proper – in the illocutionary domain identified (for now) with a non-committal xP. Encoding pragmatics in syntax is in line with much recent literature that pursues this line of inquiry (without aspirations for exhaustivity, I refer the reader to Speas & Tenny 2003, Speas 2004, Miyagawa 2012, 2022, Haegeman & Hill 2013, Portner et al. 2019, Wiltschko 2021, a.o.). Putting aside the structural specifics of the pragmatic syntax for now, what is crucial for my present purposes is that DIR is a discourse feature introduced at the non-at-issue level that is associated with the range of illocutionary forces along the lines of Han (2000). Furthermore, as is clear from (13), I am bundling DIR with the jussive-related properties, understood here as the person and number specification linked to the addressee. Such bundling is not unprecedented: most recently, it is pursued in Medeiros (2015) and Kaur (2020). Only for them, the bundle is hosted by the C-head and includes the uninterpretable second person features as well as Han's entire IMP-complex (comprising both, *directive* and *irrealis*). On the other hand, my approach entails a division of labor: only the discourse-related features (ADDRESSEE- ϕ and DIR) are grouped together and confined to their designated domain. ADDRESSEE- ϕ operates in the manner of Zanuttini et al.'s (2012) jussive operator, which agrees with and binds the subject.

One point of order concerns the number value. Zanuttini et al. (2012) place the number feature on the defective T from (7) (cf. fn 7). But this step appears to be unnecessary, considering that both ϕ -features are connected to the addressee. Hence, in my (13), x^0 is presumed to host the person and number feature alike (where ADDRESSEE- ϕ serves as a shorthand for both). Russian signposts the number value in imperatives by means of suffixation: singular has the form in (14a); plural is obtained by adding *-te* to the imperative stem, as in (14b).

- (14) a. Pojdi -Ø tuda!
 come.IMP -2.SG there
 '(You) go there!'
- b. Pojdi -te tuda!
 show.IMP -2.PL there
 '(Y'all) go there!'

This plural marker *-te* enjoys a special status in the imperative and imperative-adjacent contexts. Consider, in particular, a cohortative in (15a). It is formed by adding the plural suffix *-te* (which looks exactly like *-te* from (14b)) to the first plural indicative form (which, even on its own, can convey *let us go!*, as in (15b)).

Pojd-em-te (‘go-1PL-PL’) from (15a) is a curiosity for two reasons. First, it features an (ostensibly) redundant plural marking (i.e., *-te*). Second, Dobrushina & Goussev (2005) report that it has to be interpreted in a way that is usual for the imperatives. In the cohortatives, some speakers accept the exclusive meaning (“we (without you)”), but only if these hortatives have the morphological shape of the indicative like (15b). The redundantly marked forms are obligatorily understood inclusively by all speakers, as attested by the ungrammaticality of (16).

(15) a. *Pojd-em -te!*
 go-PRS.1PL -PL
 ‘Let us all go!’

b. *Pojd-em!*
 go-PRS.1PL
 ‘Let us all go!’

(16) **Pojd-em -te, a vy ostavajtes’!*
 go-PRS.1PL -PL but you stay
 Intended: ‘Let’s go and you remain here!’

(Dobrushina & Goussev 2005: 188)

Dobrushina & Goussev (2005) further observe that exclusives are atypical of imperatives, “[s]ince a request is normally directed to the addressee and may not easily be applied to the speaker or non-locutors” (p. 186). In view of the split between *pojdem* and *pojdem-te* just discussed, it seems productive to exploit the idea that *-te* is associated with the addressee(s) and thus necessarily prohibits the exclusive reading. So, while the number in *pojdem* is determined internally to the CP-domain, in *pojdem-te*, *-te* spells out that there are either multiple addressees or a single one (in the circumstances of polite address). Incidentally, the very fact that *-te*, alongside number, also encodes politeness indicates that the speech act layer is the appropriate domain for it. As I see no reason to treat *-te* in imperatives and cohortatives differently, I propose that *-te* spells out the number linked to the addressee with x^0 bearing the relevant features.

2.1.3 Morphological forms: a (brief) note on meaning and form

The proposal made here requires one additional amendment to Han’s system. Under her treatment, *Cirrealis* selects either subjunctives or infinitives. My CIRR can be merged with any of the temporally defective forms – infinitives, subjunctives or imperatives – owing precisely to the de-bundling of features in (13).⁸

⁸Similarly, Dobrushina (2016b) appraises subjunctives and imperatives as irrealis forms (p. 225).

This approach is justified on the empirical grounds (at least for Russian) in view of (17), which demonstrates that all three morphological forms can be used to convey strong commands. Writing on constructions like (17a), where the imperative meaning is externalized via an infinitive verbal form, Khrakovskii & Volodin (2001) observe that these constructions are commonplace in a boss's (rather than an underling's) speech (p. 197). Kalev et al. (2017) call past forms in (17b) "military imperatives".⁹

- (17) a. Sest'!
sit.down.INF
'Sit (the hell) down!'
- b. (Čtoby mne) sel!
that.SBJV me.DAT sat.down.PST.M
'Sit (the hell) down!'
- c. Sjad'!
sit.down.IMP
'Sit down!'

Importantly, my structure in (13) predicts that C should be indifferent to the morphological shape of its complement, since the force value is fixed elsewhere. That is not to say that all three morphological forms in (17) enjoy the same range of imperative meanings – but they do retain the core imperative function (i.e., conveying an order).

2.1.4 Summary

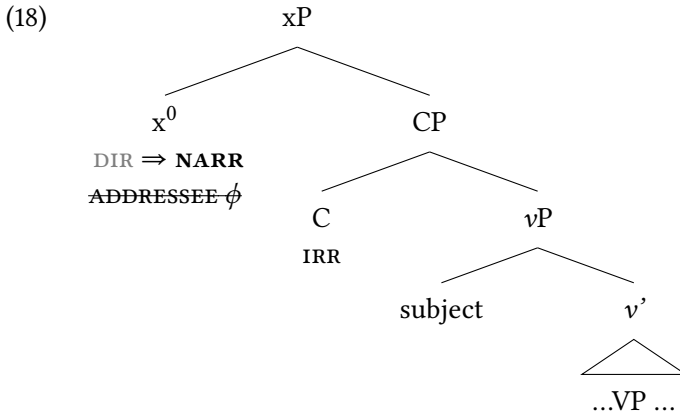
This completes the set-up, which should render my main idea quite straightforward: just as the infinitive can be a vehicle for imparting commands, so too the imperative may be pushed outside of its conventional semantic sphere. The relative autonomy of morphology and meaning falls out from the proposal in (13). In the case of NIs, what carries over from the canonical imperatives is the structural template (no T) along with the morphological shape of the verb. Lost or reinterpreted are the pragmatic features – narrative imperatives impose no subject restrictions and, with ADDRESSEE- ϕ features, they also lose the range of typical imperative forces. In other words, the "culprit" here is what I have tentatively

⁹They discuss forms like *Sel!* 'sat.down.PST.M' (Sit down!), which can denote forceful commands even in the absence of the subjunctive context (i.e., as stand-alone sentences). I suspect that *Sel!* is derived from *Čtoby mne sel!* in (17b). Since the point is orthogonal to the issue, I will not pursue it here.

designated as x^0 – the relevant head in the pragmatic domain. The next section spells out the details.

2.2 Narrative imperatives: big picture

I suggest that the narrative imperative borrows the structure of the conventional imperative but re-configures its discourse layer, as sketched in (18). This latter process happens under the influence of the partial morphological overlap with the aorist. The upshot is that NIs combine (i) the clausal (T-less) template of the canonical imperative as well as its morphological form with (ii) certain meaning traits that were brought about by analogy with the aorist.¹⁰



The structure in (18) is meant to capture two things. It represents the structure of NIs in the contemporary language and it also demonstrates how this representation came to be. Synchronically, in the narrative configurations, CP identifies truth-conditional content – with C^0 bearing the familiar IRR and the subject imposing no restrictions. A Speech Act-related xP, the head of which carries a feature NARR, is built above CP.

¹⁰ Anonymous Reviewer suggests a link between my proposal and what has been pursued in the literature under the rubric of “constructional contamination” (in, e.g., Pijpops & Van de Velde 2016, Pijpops et al. 2018). This is not quite accurate. Under their original conception, the term applies (crudely) in the following circumstances: a meaning X can be conveyed via a form A^1 or its minimally different variant A^2 . The source for the latter is a (contaminating) construction B, which is structurally unrelated to A^1 but accidentally resembles it. This is not my situation here. NIs and canonical imperatives are not variants of each other in this sense. Rather, they are identical in form and – if I am right – share some structural idiosyncrasies, but they diverge in semantics. This latter distinction arises due to analogical influence from a morphologically convergent form that supplies some aspects of the meaning.

Diachronically, those elements identified with a strike-through were lost and those marked with a long arrow ($\Rightarrow$) were re-conceptualized. The obvious point of divergence concerns the addressee-related property that ensures a particular discourse orientation of the subject: as shown by the contrast in (19), the subject of the NI is not limited to the second person – and hence de-links the subject from the addressee.¹¹ The second update concerns the pragmatic operator DIR. In narrative contexts, it acquires a slightly different function that I will call NARR. Crucially though, NIs retain the performativity of the canonical imperatives – formally encoded in the (extra-clausal) structure. The claim here is the diachronic changes just enumerated are a consequence of a morphological “misparsing” of the (moribund) aorist.

- (19) a. A on vdrug [?](i) napiši žalobu.
 and he suddenly and(.FOC) write.NI complaint
 ‘And he writes a complaint all of a sudden.’ (NI)
- b. ⟨Ty / *On ⟩ napiši žalobu!
 you / he write.IMP complaint
 ‘You (*he) write the complaint!’ (canonical imperative)

To recap: I defend two distinct sets of claims. The first one centers around my proposals pertaining to the syntactic shape of NIs in contemporary Russian; the second one is an outline of the diachronic route that lead to this shape. The rest of this section is organized to follow this division.

That NIs share some structural idiosyncrasies with the canonical imperatives is the central claim of this paper. If we concede that imperatives are distinct from other clause types (in lacking certain functional structure), we anticipate for NIs to be likewise deficient in the relevant domain. §2.3 spells out my rationale for making this claim. This section presents evidence that NIs are T-less and explains the contributions of IRR and the newly introduced NARR.

In §2.4, I present some evidence that the two imperative constructions exhibit similar behavior in a handful of syntactic contexts. We will see that they do not embed, cannot participate in information-seeking questions, and pattern together with respect to the discourse particle *-ka*. These properties are linked to the performativity of the two imperatives.

Finally, in §2.5, I explain the relevance of the aorist to the emergence of this construction.

¹¹There is a preference for *i* ‘and.FOC’ in (19a). This is addressed in §3.

2.3 Narrative imperatives: tense, irrealis and the speech act domain

The conclusions that NIs lack certain functional components is based on two observations. First, the construction shows no vestiges of agreement. Second, its temporal value is underspecified.

The agreement patterns are revealed in (20) and (21) for canonical imperatives and NIs, respectively. Recall that the run-of-the-mill imperatives incorporate a specification for number (encoded by the suffix *-te*) (see also (14)) – something that is unavailable to NIs. In fact, the form of the verb in narrative contexts remains invariable independent of the person. This failure of the two imperatives to match completely seems to contradict my claim about their structural convergence. But this is only apparent.

- (20) a. Pokaži -te -s' zavtra!
show.IMP -2PL -REFL tomorrow
'(Y'all) show up tomorrow!'
b. Pokaži -Ø -s' zavtra!
show.IMP -2SG -REFL tomorrow
'(You) show up tomorrow!'
- (21) a. *A tut okaži -te -s' vy, da?
and here appear.NI -2PL -REFL you.2PL yes
Intended: 'And then you appeared, right?'
b. A tut okaži -Ø -s' vy, da?
and here appear.NI -2SG -REFL you.2PL yes
'And then you appeared, right?'

Recall that under my analysis, the number and person specifications are situated in the pragmatic domain – grouped under ADDRESSEE- ϕ , as in (22). The narrative imperative distinguishes itself from the canonical one by the featural composition of x^0 : this head in the speech act layer ceases to host any ϕ -features associated with the addressee, as indicated in (18). For this reason, the suffix *-te*, taken here as a spell-out of the number specification, does not resurface in the narratives.

- (22) ADDRESSEE- ϕ : $\left[\begin{array}{l} \text{person: 2} \\ \text{number: } _ \end{array} \right]_i$

Note as well that this analysis enables us to derive one side benefit: in particular, the oft noted absence of any subject restrictions follows naturally from my proposal, as nothing in this system prevents the compatibility of impersonals with

NIs. Consider for instance the contrast in (23): *vytošnit* ‘(cause) to vomit’ shows default neuter agreement and takes on the sole argument in the accusative; its close synonym, *nablevat* ‘to puke’ agrees with the subject in the nominative (shown in the (b)-examples below as a measure of contrast). Some argue that *vytošnit* is lexically specified to be incompatible with a subject of any kind (e.g., Lavine & Babby 2019, Babby 2009). For Zimmerling (2013), *vytošnit* requires a null subject, $\emptyset^{3.SG}$, specified as “non-human, non-animated generic Agent triggering a non-controlled process.” On either account, the pattern in (24) is straightforward: ADDRESSEE- ϕ conflicts with Zimmerling’s $\emptyset^{3.SG}$ or a nil subject of Lavine & Babby. But since the NI’s subjects are not bound by a higher operator, they are unconstrained, as shown in (25). This liberty, in turn, means that NIs are perfectly suitable for the predicates that denote non-controllable processes.

- (23) a. ⟨*On / Ego⟩ vytošnilo.
 he.NOM / him.ACC vomited.PST.N (-AGR)
 ‘He vomited (i.e., something caused him to vomit).’
 b. ⟨On / *Ego⟩ nableval.
 he.NOM / him.ACC puked.PST.M (+AGR)
 ‘He puked.’
- (24) a. *Vytošni!
 vomit.IMP
 Intended: ‘Vomit!’
 b. Nabluj!
 puke.IMP
 ‘Puke!’
- (25) a. A tut ego ^{?(i)} vytošni ot zapaxa...
 and here him.ACC and(.FOC) vomit.NI from smell
 ‘And then the smell makes him vomit.’
 b. A tut on ^{?(i)} nabluj...
 and here he.ACC and(.FOC) vomit.NI
 ‘And then he suddenly pukes.’

Concerning the temporal value, earlier I cited Isachenko 1960 (repeated in (26) from (3)) who challenges the standard appraisal of the NI as a conveyor of the past tense. Recall that for him, the narrative temporality is quirky: the NI construction is synonymous with the historical present (i.e., a vivid narrative conveyed via the present tense morphology) rather than the standard preterit.

- (26) a. Ja k nemu po-xorošemu, a on (i) nakriči na menja.
 I to him well but he and(.FOC) scream.NI on me
 ‘I’m being nice to him – and suddenly he yells at me.’
 b. ... a on kak nakričit na menja.
 but he how screams.3SG.PFV on me
 ‘I’m being nice to him – and suddenly he yells at me.’

Indeed, I believe that the temporal value of the narrative imperative is not fixed at all (this conclusion is also reached in Fortuin 2001). For instance, (27) shows future orientation. (27a) was sourced online and reproduced here in its entirety. It comes with a pseudo-coordinated add-on (i.e., *voz’mi da i* ‘take.NI and’). The version in (27b) is elicited to complete the minimal pair with (27a) – absent here is the pseudo-coordinate component. My consultants prefer for *vyjdi* to be preceded by *i* but accept the version without it. Pseudo-coordination and the nature of *i* will be addressed in §3. For now, it will suffice to observe that in either variant of (27), the speaker is talking about the past, as is clear from the verb forms in the opening clause. The element *mol* “[I] thought / said” is best understood as a direct speech marker – it commences the clause that communicates a future contingency, which evidently serves as the appropriate environment for the NIs. A similar example is found in (28), where the temporal reference is unambiguously fixed in the future.¹²

- (27) a. Ešče byli takie mysli, mol, kuplju, a zavtra
 also were such thoughts I.thought will.buy.1SG but tomorrow
voz’mi da i vyjdi licenzionnoe izdanie.
 take.NI DA and come.out.NI licensed edition
 ‘And so my thought was: I’ll buy it – and then a licensed edition will
 suddenly come out.’ (movie forum.2005)
 b. Ešče byli takie mysli, mol, kuplju, a zavtra (
 also were such thoughts I.thought will.buy.1SG but tomorrow
 i) vyjdi licenzionnoe izdanie. Togda čto?
 and(.FOC) come.out.NI licensed edition then what
 ‘And so my thought was: I’ll buy it – and then a licensed edition will
 come out. Then what?’

¹²Of the time of this writing, the source for this example unfortunately went defunct.

- (28) *Eto ščas servernye procy ne adaptirovani (...), a zavtra*
 this now server processors NEG adapted but tomorrow
voz'mi da i vyjdi zaplatka.
 take.NI DA and come.out.NI patch
 'While now the server processors are not adapted, a patch may come out
 tomorrow.'
 (computer forum)

To sum up, in NIs, the temporal value is not rigid and the agreement is nonexistent. These two facts signify that, first, T cannot be present in NI configurations, and second, there is no ADDRESSEE- ϕ . In other words, the narrative imperative is structurally identical to the canonical imperative – but, in contrast to the canonical imperative, it does not impose any addressee-related restrictions. This latter property is tied to the feature I called NARR. The rest of this section considers its contribution along with the role of IRR.

The crucial property of NIs lies in their performativity. After all, their *raison d'être* is to serve as a vehicle for imparting a narrative. It has been repeatedly noted that the form is frequent in oral speech, folklore, *skaz*, and literature. Obviously, to tell a story, one does not only use the NI forms. In fact, as noted by Holvoet (2018) (with antecedent sources cited therein), one cannot really construct a complete narrative using the NI as the sole verbal form – at best, NIs are confined to a couple of sentences within an extended discourse. Moreover, those sentences need to impart something unexpected. In short, NIs are quite fussy about their environments: they are used to recount an out of the ordinary turn of events within a narrative. They are necessarily contrastive, as they stand in opposition to the conventional practice or predictable outcomes. If we accept that NIs represent a grammatical marker of narrativity, this contrastive property is not entirely surprising. As suggested earlier, this rather unique form serves to earmark something special in the narrative. The proposal hence is that it is slotted precisely for the events that need to be opposed in some way to the usual, i.e. the mirative property is simply a consequence of the form's contextual selectivity.

As indicated in (18), DIR gives way to NARR. Why this happens is outlined in §2.5. Here I concentrate on the nature of this new feature. Searle (1975) provides a helpful framework for this. Reflecting on the nature of fiction (one way for relaying a story), he rejects the idea that it requires an independent repertoire of speech acts (i.e., “telling a story” vs. standard illocutionary acts such as, e.g., making an assertion or asking a question). Instead, he reasons that a writer (and presumably a raconteur) “is acting as if she were making an assertion, or going

through the motion of making an assertion, or imitating the making of an assertion” (p. 324). He concludes that integral to this understanding of fiction are the illocutionary intentions of the author. What is required is the suspension of commitments to the set of the usual semantic and pragmatic rules. For instance, a fictional story-teller does not commit herself to the truth of the expressed proposition. Though I will not attempt to formalize it, this approximates the way I envision NARR: it is an instruction to the hearer’s to treat the proposition as a story – with the requisite assumptions regarding the truth-commitments of the speaker.¹³

Finally, onto IRR: its job is to fix the temporal-modal value relative to the illocutionary properties of the clause – it relativizes events to the components of the speech act. We can think of IRR in these contexts as a story-reality, constructed by the speaker, where the tense value is diegetic to the story (i.e., story-internal).

With this piece in place, the picture should now be clear. A narrative imperative “owes” its structure to the conventional one. It retains its IRR specification that serves to express temporality within the narrative domain. The typical imperative meanings (encoded as DIR) are replaced by the newly acquired NARR that signals that the embedded proposition is akin to a language game, in which the conventional commitments cease to apply. Finally, NIs do not introduce ADDRESSEE ϕ , which eliminates all subject restrictions and the number morphology tied to the addressee.

2.4 Narrative imperatives: intersection with canonical imperatives

The next section contains additional support for treating NIs as an imperative specimen. The two imperatives exhibit identical behavior with respect to three diagnostics. They resist embedding (§2.4.1), are ineligible in information seeking questions (§2.4.2), and compatible with the discourse marker *-ka* (§2.4.3). The utility of the exercise is predicated on the assumption that the common patterns indicate a convergence on a more abstract level. I tentatively ascribe the commonalities between NIs and canonical imperatives to the speech act layer (my xP) that constrains them in similar ways.

¹³This is admittedly vague. For now, I will keep it at this level of terseness, leaving it to future endeavors to tease out the contributions and the nature of xP and what I call NARR. On the intersection of a speaker’s commitment and the speech act layer, see esp. Krifka 2021, Miyagawa 2022.

2.4.1 Embedding

“Just occasionally imperatives can be used in *bona fide* dependent clauses” (Aikhenvald 2010: 109). The corpus of counterexamples to this generalization is growing, although languages impose various restrictions on the embedded (morphological) imperatives (see Stegovec & Kaufmann 2015 and references therein). Russian behaves in a more conventional manner: under reportive verbs, the embedded clause cannot contain a predicate bearing imperative morphology (29a). Instead, it must be paraphrased as in (29b) by a directive subjunctive.

- (29) a. *On skazal, čto ty napiši žalobu.
 he said that you write.IMP complaint
 Intended: ‘He said that you should write a complaint.’
 b. On skazal, čtoby ty napisal žalobu.
 he said that.SBJV you wrote.PST.M complaint
 ‘He said that you should write a complaint.’

Consider now (30) in light of this injunction. Evidently, embedded clauses containing NIs (30a) likewise resist embedding (cf. the finite variety in (30b)).¹⁴

- (30) a. *On skazal, čto ty včera (i) napiši žalobu.
 he said that you yesterday and(.FOC) write.NI complaint
 Intended: ‘He said that you wrote a complaint yesterday.’
 b. Ja skazal, čto ty včera napisal žalobu.
 I said that you yesterday wrote.PST.M complaint
 ‘I said that you wrote a complaint yesterday.’

The core idea here is that both imperatives, by virtue of representing a speech act, resist embedding and hence belong in the range of root clause phenomena (see Miyagawa 2022 for a literature overview and discussion). Their illocutionary properties, encoded in the speech act layer, hinder their eligibility in positions of verbal complementation.

¹⁴Anonymous Reviewer observes that the embedded clause from (30a) can be a constituent in situations of clausal coordination – *We didn’t think he would do it [but he wrote.NI the complaint]* – which is a kind of syntactic layering. Still, I take these instances to fall within the purview of root phenomena, since, as Reviewer him/herself notes, such coordinate structures resist further embedding. See also Krifka (2014).

2.4.2 Eligibility in questions

Russian also complies with the standard view that questions and imperatives, instantiating different clause types, are mutually incompatible (Sadock & Zwicky 1985).¹⁵ This holds of directive imperatives in conventional, i.e. information seeking, contexts like (31). Here I concentrate on the polar interrogatives (the same set of generalizations applies to wh-questions).

- (31) *Ty pročitaĭ knigu?
 you read.IMP book
 Intended: ‘Should you read the book?’

It is, however, possible to force an imperative into a question that bears citation quality. (32) convey incredulity or surprise. Observe that the question has no person restrictions and the case is assigned to the subject by default – nominative in Russian (*on*) / accusative in English (*him*). Both languages require a particularly expressive intonation to make (32) work: the prosodic emphasis on the subject is accompanied by a pause after it.

- (32) (S1: Ivan emu i govorit: “Pročitaĭ *Vojnu i mir*!”)
 ‘So, Ivan says to him: Read *War and Peace*!’
 S2: ON pročitaĭ *Vojnu i mir*? Da on ničego dlinnee tvitov ne čital!
 he read.IMP *War and Peace* DA he nothing longer tweets NEG read
 ‘HIM read *War and Peace*? He hasn’t read anything longer than a tweet!’

Just like their canonical counterparts, NIs are deviant in (standard, information seeking) questions: (33a), featuring a narrative imperative, cannot be uttered in the out of an blue context in contrast to its indicative counterpart (33b).

- (33) a. *Skaži, on (i) napiši rabotu?
 tell he and(.FOC) wrote.NI work
 Intended: ‘Tell me, did he finish the paper?’
 b. Skaži, on napisal rabotu?
 tell he wrote.PST.M work
 ‘Tell me, did he finish the paper?’

While prohibited in information seeking interrogatives, NIs may participate in “declarative” questions like (34), which set themselves apart from the conventional questions by rising intonation.¹⁶ (34a) would be an appropriate response

¹⁵But see Kaufmann & Poschmann (2013), Stegovec (2017).

¹⁶(33a) can be made compatible with this reading.

to a gullible interlocutor, recounting a scam incident he fell victim to: “So, this guy said he could get me to meet Taylor Swift if I paid him \$500”. The question in (34b) may be uttered to a child who was asked not to reveal a secret. Such questions hence seek to confirm that a certain (unexpected) action was carried out in contravention of common sense or a prior injunction.

- (34) a. A ty (i) pover’ emu?
and you and(.FOC) believe.NI him
‘And you believed him?’
b. A ty (i) skaži babuške, da?
and you and(.FOC) tell.NI grandma yes
‘But you told grandma, didn’t you?’ (modified from Vinogradov 1947)

Hence, the directive imperatives are suitable for surprise questions (*Him read War and Peace?*), while the narrative ones participate in confirmative questions ($\approx$...and you told grandma?). As it happens, the two types share something in common. Jeong (2018) groups them under the umbrella of “inquisitive rising questions”, which represent “a marked way of asking” and require a yes-answer (as opposed to an *oh*-answer). It seems to me that when imperatives appear in questions, they are interpreted akin to direct speech – roughly, something like: does it really hold of *x* that *x* was involved in the following speech act: [_{SPEECH ACT} narrative about *x* / command issued to *x*]? I will leave the issue at that, conceding, however, that the facts in (31) and (33a) may ultimately require distinct explanations. At the very least, the commonalities are suggestive – and upon this initial approach, it would seem fruitful to situate them within the same analytical scheme.

Before moving on, I would be remiss not to relay a short aside. It has been claimed in the literature that second person is impossible in NI contexts (e.g., Khrakovskii & Volodin 2001) or at least extremely rare. Moloshnaia (2009) implies that the *you*-forms are restricted to questions. This is not quite accurate. They are best in questions for pragmatic reasons. Indeed, it is hard to narrate a story whose protagonist is also the addressee. Hard, but not impossible, as demonstrated by (35), where the speaker recites an anecdote about the addressee to the addressee as an inducement for recollection.

- (35) Nu vot, slovom, sidit Ivan Il’ič osolovevšij. A ty emu (i)
so in.word sits Ivan Ilich in.stupor but you to.him and(.FOC)
skaži: “...!” Razve ne pomniš’?
say.NI ... really NEG remember
‘So, there is Ivan Ilich in a stupor. And you suddenly go: ‘...!’ Don’t you

remember?’

2.4.3 Compatibility with *-ka*

This section is about the word order facts with the discourse element *-ka* (discussed in Vinogradov 1947, Khrakovskii & Volodin 2001, Fortuin 2001, 2008, Dobrushina 2016a). Its optimal context is in combination with an imperative (36a) or a perfective future first singular form, to which Khrakovskii & Volodin (2001) ascribe imperative-like meaning (36b).¹⁷ Its semantic contribution is described in some detail in Khrakovskii & Volodin (2001): 178-185. What is important for present purposes is that first, the felicity of *-ka* depends on whether both the speaker and the addressee are “actualized” (in Khrakovskii & Volodin’s terminology). This amounts to a requirement that there are explicit discourse participants. For this reason, *-ka* is incompatible with imperatives conveying general instructions which are not directed to or issued by any particular person (e.g., *in the event of fire use the stairs*). Second, *-ka* can only be used if both discourse participants know each other and the speaker outranks the listener in the social hierarchy.

- (36) a. Prinesi-ka mne dnevnik!
 bring.IMP-*ka* to.me diary
 ‘Bring me the diary, will you?’ (–*ka* in imperatives)
- b. Pojdu-ka ja domoj.
 will.go.1SG-*ka* I home
 ‘I better go home.’ (–*ka* in future)

Given this description, there should be little doubt that *-ka* belongs in the pragmatic domain. Further confirmation is furnished by (37), which shows that even when *-ka* combines with an indicative morphological form, the clause containing it cannot embed.

- (37) *Ja skazal, čto pročitaju-ka ja novosti.
 I said that will.read.1SG-*ka* I news
 Intended: ‘I said that I better read the news.’

The crucial contrast is provided in (38) vs. (39). Observe that in indicative contexts (38), the verb+*ka* must precede the subject; in imperative environments, it need not to (39).

¹⁷This particle *-ka* is also found in certain subjunctives and biased questions.

- (38) a. ?*Ja pročitaju-ka novosti.
I will.read.1SG-*ka* news
Intended: ‘I better read the news.’
b. Pročitaju-ka ja novosti.
will.read.1SG-*ka* I news
‘I better read the news.’
- (39) a. Ty prinesi-ka mne gazetu.
you bring.IMP-*ka* to.me newspaper
‘Bring me the newspaper, will you?’
b. Prinesi-ka ty mne, Van’, gazetu.
bring.IMP-*ka* you to.me Vanya newspaper
‘Bring me the newspaper, will you, Vanya?’

Now, contrary to the claim in Fortuin (2001) that *-ka* is illicit in NI contexts, my informants find no fault with (40). They further report that *-ka* feels especially natural in PC contexts (attached to the first conjunct, i.e. *voz’mi*) and with reportive verbs (*say, blab, prattle*).¹⁸ In syntax, the NI is parallel to the canonical imperative, i.e., Subject»V=*ka* word order is allowed.

- (40) a. Nu tut ja (i) skaži-ka: “...!”
so here I and(.FOC) say.NI-*ka*
‘And so I go: ...!’
b. Tut on voz’mi-ka i brjakni: “Ne obaldel li ty, Ivan
here he take.NI-*ka* and blab.NI NEG lost.mind Q you Ivan
Andreevich?”
Andreevich
‘And he goes and says: *Are you out of your mind, Ivan Andreevich?*’

The contribution of *-ka* in NI contexts appears to be vacuous: its function is simply to signal the involvement of the hearer – to ensure s/he is paying attention (*≈and he, get this, goes and says...*). Meaning aside, central for present purposes are the word order facts. In directives and narratives, the verb accompanied by *-ka* is flexible. It may appear before or after the subject in contrast to the context with the indicative form, where the verbal complex is confined to the clause-initial position. While remaining noncommittal to the details of the pragmatic syntax, I simply want to highlight that contrary to the established view, this imperative-exclusive particle *-ka* is not only possible with the ostensibly “non-imperative”

¹⁸This preference for PC with NIs holds with or without *-ka*. See §2.2.

form but, when in combination with the latter, the resulting complex patterns with the canonical imperative.

2.4.4 Recap

The goal of this section was to catalog the convergent behaviors characteristic of the two imperatives. It is, indeed, a curious coincidence that these two forms that allegedly have “nothing in common” with each other should pattern alike. Under the proposals developed here, they are identical not only in their external shape, but in sharing certain (unique) abstract traits as well.

2.5 Contribution of Aorist

In this section, I offer some conjectures on the provenance of the NI.¹⁹ A brief set-up is in order, as this is the juncture I bring back the character from earlier – the aorist, a past tense verbal form, attested overwhelmingly with the perfective verbs (Borkovskii & Kuznetsov 2006: 269). Most historians of the language believe in its early obsolescence in the colloquial speech of the Eastern Slavs. In Zalizniak (2004)’s assessment, by the 12th c., it was relegated to the domain of passive knowledge: while speakers knew how to use it, they avoided it outside of the literary sphere. He compares the situation to contemporary BCS, whose aorist is the province of literature, and French, where *passé simple* is likewise restricted to the written domain.

With that insight, consider again Table 2, which shows that for a subset of verbs, the forms of aorist.2/3.SG and imperative.2/3.SG are indistinguishable.²⁰ Now suppose we have a learner caught in the stage where the aorist is going out of use. Her exposure to it is hence extremely limited. When confronted with ambiguous forms like (41) (i.e., verbs in *-iti*), she interprets them as the imperatives (undoubtedly a more frequent usage), which are somehow sometimes available in the assertive contexts. So, due to the morphological confusion, the learner fuses the two: from the imperative, she takes the sentential template and the morphology itself; and from the aorist – its narrative properties. The casualty of this aorist influence (i.e., the learner’s observation that forms like *pomoli* are

¹⁹I am assuming the acquisition based model of language change (Lightfoot 1999, 2010, Roberts 2018, Roberts & Roussou 2003, etc.)

²⁰Anonymous Reviewer wonders if the *-iti* verbs were the most frequent verbs in Old East Slavic. I do not have an answer to this question and, in any case, implicated here is a particular form in a paradigm of a given stem-type (the frequency of which should presumably be extrapolated from the contemporary usage and correlated with the available corpora). Following Ambridge et al. (2015), I acknowledge the utility of this metric and leave this issue for future investigation.

sometimes eligible in the assertive contexts) is the DIR-feature (and the subject restrictions that go along with it). The speech act layer is then repurposed to fit the story-telling characteristics, consistent with the appearance of the aorist in descriptions, recitals, biblical tales etc. This ultimately results in the availability of the synchronic structure (18).

- (41) pomoli = pomoli
 pray.AOR.2/3SG pray.IMP.2/(3)SG
 'S/he prayed. // Pray!' (Old East Slavic)

First, (43) introduces a coordinate structure, where the first conjunct *voz'mi* is semantically bleached, grammaticalized and inert for theta-assignment. The coordinator itself is available in several varieties – *da*, *da i*, *i* and nothing (i.e., as an instance of a serial verb).²¹ Furthermore, the availability of such coordination (i.e., *take &* is not some unique property of NIs: PC is well-attested in finite contexts like (44). In addition to these observations, most people agree that the construction *take &*, whether in its indicative or narrative incarnation, conveys a sense that the events are unexpected or contrary to the established norms (e.g., Fortuin 2001, Rodionova 2010, Weiss 2022a,b, 2023, and references therein).

- (43) A ded voz'mi < da / da i / i / – > umri.
 and grandpa take.NI DA / DA and / and / – die.NI
 ‘And grandpa goes and dies all of a sudden.’
- (44) Molodoženy pozvali na svad'bu Kianu Rivza, a on vzjal i
 newlyweds invited to wedding Keanu Reeves but he took.PST.M and
 prišel.
 came.PST.M
 ‘The newlyweds invited Keanu Reeves to their wedding – and he showed
 up (contrary to expectations).’ (web)

I will put aside the issue of coordinators and the nature of pseudo-coordination itself, noting only that the issue has been tackled by many (Ross 2021, Giusti et al. 2022 and references therein). Quite a few authoritative analyses endorse a monoclausal configuration for PC constructions (see Biberauer & Vikner 2017, Cardinaletti & Giusti 2001, Ross 2021, etc.), where the first conjunct is a grammaticalized element introduced above *v*. I tentatively accept that and move to the question: why is PC so pervasive with the NIs? Indeed, it is hard to source many examples of the solo NIs (i.e. when the form appears in non-coordinated contexts), which, presumably, is the reason why PC is often assumed (implicitly or explicitly) to be an integral component of the narrative construction.

Despite this, I argued that the mirative properties of NIs are independent of *take &*-construction. They arise in response to the discourse demands: as this form has a narrow function, it is reserved for contrast – i.e., when a narrator seeks to surprise their interlocutor with an unexpected turn of events. If so, the

²¹Anonymous Reviewer queries if *da* is strictly a coordinator given that it is cognate with the Balkan complementizer. In Russian, *da* can appear in conventional coordination contexts, carrying a slightly antiquated tinge, e.g., *Ivan da Mar'ja* ‘Ivan and Maria’ or *smotrit da prigovari-vae* ‘watches and says’ or to convey sequential events, e.g., *vstal da vyšel* ‘got up and left’.

contribution of *take &* is redundant in NI contexts (in contrast to their indicative counterparts). Its job here is that of emphasis. Note as well that the redundancy of this kind is not unusual, as confirmed by (45): a competent editor may frown upon this sequence of nearly complete synonyms, but the sentence is not incoherent. The upshot is that the *take &*-component is a pleonastic add-on whose frequency with NIs is a consequence of the conventionalized usage.

- (45) Vdrug on neožidanno, ni s togo ni s sego, bez
 suddenly he unexpectedly NEG from this NEG from that without
 vsjakoj pričiny voz'mi i brjakni...
 any reason take.NI and blab.NI
 'Suddenly he unexpectedly, out of the blue, for no good reason goes and blabs...'

A related issue is illustrated by (46). Fortuin (2001) observes that in non-coordinated narrative contexts, the verb strongly prefers to be preceded by *i*, as shown in (46). The same holds of my earlier constructed examples.

- (46) a. Ego ždut, a on i opozdaj na celyj čas.
 him wait but he and(.FOC) be.late.NI for entire hour
 'With everybody waiting for him, he shows up an hour late.'
 b. ?Ego ždut, a on opozdaj.NI na celyj čas.
 him wait but he Ø be.late for entire hour
 'With everybody waiting for him, he shows up an hour late.'

(Fortuin 2001: 140)

As is well-known, *i*, glossed in this paper as 'and(.FOC)', is a multi-functional element: depending on the context, it can be interpreted as a coordinator or an item that contributes to the performative aspect. For instance, its meaning in (47) is hardly that of a conjunction – rather, in the appraisal of Shvedova (1980): 727, it is a “modal particle” that transmits emotional attitudes of a speaker. Likewise, in (46a), *i* is best understood as an element linked to the speaker (i.e., it is associated with the discursive domain). Indeed, one can hardly find a more fitting environment for an element that channels a narrator's disposition. After all, “in sentences involving dramatic imperative, the speaker is “in charge” of the action”(Aikhenvald 2010: 249).²² Details of implementation will depend on the version of the pragmatic syntax one assumes. Though I remain uncommitted to the technical details for now, I think Biberauer & Vikner (2017) and Biberauer (2018) offer a particularly promising perspective that accommodates these data.

²²See Holvoet (2018) for a history of that quote.

- (47) a. Ne rodila mužiku, vot on i smylsja.
 NEG birthed guy.DAT lo he and(.FOC) dipped
 ‘You didn’t bother giving him a child – so he dipped.’
 b. Nu on i durak!
 well he and(.FOC) fool
 ‘He is such a fool!’

In short, the narrative imperative comes with a complication: this verb form is rarely encountered by itself. Instead, it is most natural as part of a PC-construction or preceded by the element *i*. Both of these facts are explained here by the usage preferences. *Take &* is viewed as an add-on that serves as an emphatic device in a story-telling exercise. The speaker-oriented *i* is most natural (and hence preferred) in a discourse where the speaker role is accorded a particular degree of significance.

4 Conclusion

Examples like (48) proved to be a rather fruitful research area with many components ripe for investigation. The verb in (48) is equipped with non-agreeing imperative morphology. Its existence informs our understanding of language change and reveals a cluster of properties that intersect with more familiar constructions – it has bearing on the properties of imperatives, the role of discourse components, and (to a lesser extent) the phenomenon of pseudo-coordination.

- (48) A ded [?](i) umri.
 and grandpa and(.FOC) die.NI
 ‘And grandpa suddenly dies.’

Under my analysis, the form *umri* from (48) is an instance of a “real” imperative, albeit deficient in features. In particular, the NI retains the idiosyncratic structure of the imperative clause but lacks the range of directive forces (encoded as a DIR feature). This proposal is informed by exigencies of diachrony: a subset of verbal forms, exhibiting identical morphology in the aorist and the imperative, paved a path for a reanalysis. Once the speakers begin to interpret these convergent forms as (morphological) imperatives, they extend the generalization to non-*iti* verbs. More abstractly, the imperative clause is claimed to be retrofitted with the new pragmatic function, consistent with the input “imperative but with no directive component” (encoded as NARR in the speech act layer). Conversely, the component associated with the conventional directive forces (DIR) is lost. But

since DIR is intertwined with the hearer-orientation (what I called ADDRESSEE- ϕ , which specifies person and number), subject restrictions cease to apply in narrative environments. Retained in the NI contexts is IRR, a feature that is linked to the diegetic temporality of a narrative.

My background assumption for the conventional imperative clause entails the absence of certain functional components and a rich pragmatic structure above CP. But if the NIs adopt the imperative template, then we expect for them to be likewise functionally deficient. There are three arguments to support this assertion: (i) the narrative imperative shows no vestiges of agreement; (ii) its temporal value is underspecified – contrary to the standard descriptions, it is compatible with future-oriented (not just past) contexts; (iii) it patterns with the conventional imperative in a handful of environments. Concerning the latter point, I showed that both constructions: (i) resist embedding (to embed, imperatives must be paraphrased as subjunctive clauses, while “narrative imperatives” are substituted for the agreeing indicative verbs); (ii) are ineligible in “neutral” questions (although they are possible in “inquisitive declaratives”); (iii) display the same kind of word order flexibility with the discourse marker *-ka*.

I acknowledged that NIs are most frequently encountered in pseudo-coordinated constructions like (49). In all contexts (narrative imperative or finite) the first conjunct, *take*, conveys the sense that the event expressed by the lexical verb clashes with the normative or contextual expectations – that it is unexpected. However, this mirative sense is also inherent in the solo NI (due to the specialized nature of this form). I hence suggested that the bleached coordinate (*take*) is a redundant supplement that is no different than an adverb with the same meaning (*unexpectedly*, *out of the blue*, *suddenly*, etc.) which can be introduced simply for stylistic reasons.

- (49) A ded voz'mi i umri.
 and grandpa take.NI and die.NI
 ‘And grandpa suddenly goes and dies.’

Finally, the element *i* from (48) is analyzed as an element that conveys a speaker perspective. It is optional, but strongly preferred with NIs precisely because a speaker is integral to a narrative.

Abbreviations

1	first person	N	neuter
2	second person	NEG	negation
3	third person	NI	narrative imperative
ACC	accusative	NOM	nominative
AGR	agreement	PFV	perfective
AOR	aurist	PL	plural
DAT	dative	PRS	present
FOC	focus	PST	past
IMP	imperative	Q	question marker
IPFV	imperfective	SBJV	subjunctive
INF	infinitive	SG	singular
M	masculine		

Acknowledgments

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